Canadian Payment Scam Intelligence Brief

Data through 2025-09 · CAFC Fraud Reporting System + 83 CAFC bulletins · Prepared October 22, 2026 · Independent analysis of public data

Investment scams now own 54% of all fraud losses, up 26% year-over-year with median victim loss climbing from $25K to $32K. Recovery pitches surged 336%, re-victimizing the same pool at $15.6M in six months.

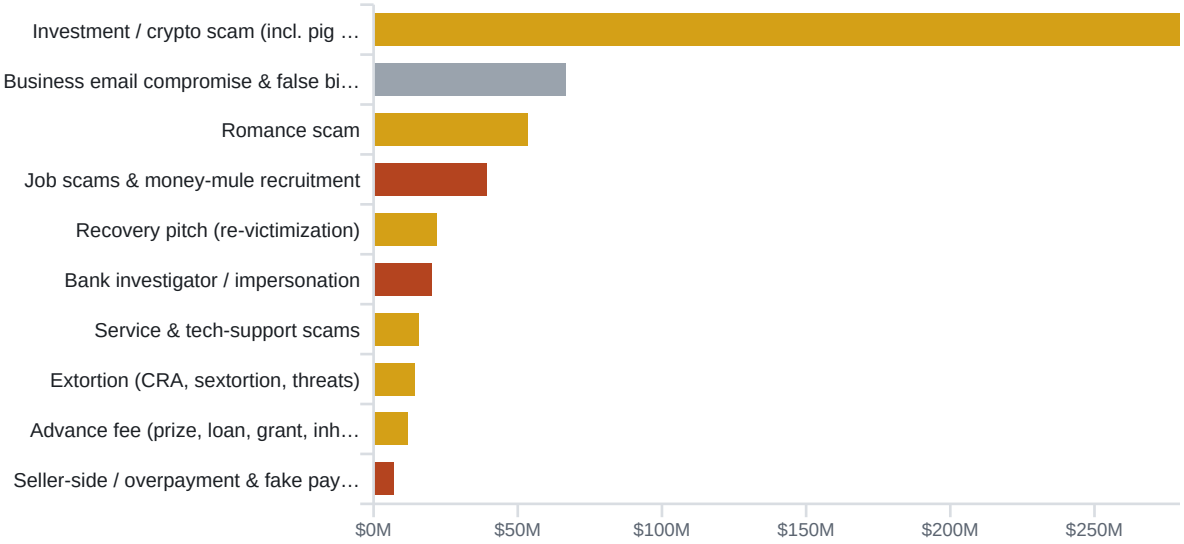
Reports (12 mo)	Victim reports	Reported losses	Losses: victims 60+
37,102	**26,321**	**$564M**	**37%**

Period: 2024-10 to 2025-09.

Key judgements

- Investment and crypto scams drove $151.4M in losses across six months (54% of total), with robust 26% growth despite flat report volumes.
- Recovery pitch losses exploded 336% to $15.6M as median loss per victim more than doubled from $7,550 to $17,575.
- Romance scams posted 26% loss growth to $26M with median loss jumping from $20,600 to $30K, signaling deeper victim exploitation.
- Text message contact share rose 2.2 percentage points while direct calls fell 1.0 point, suggesting fraudsters are shifting to asynchronous channels that evade real-time intervention.

Where reported losses concentrate (last 12 months)



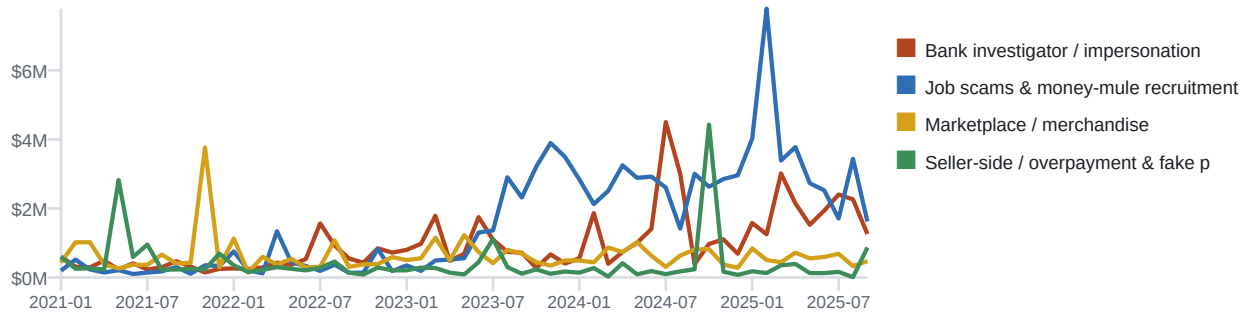
Bar colour = likely Interac exposure: High Medium Low. Exposure is an analyst judgement of how often the scam's money moves over e-Transfer/debit rather than crypto, cards or gift cards.

What's growing: 2025-04 to 2025-09 vs 2024-04 to 2024-09 (same months a year earlier)

Typology	Interac exp.	Reports	Rpts YoY	Losses	Losses YoY	Median loss	60+ share
Investment / crypto scam (incl. pig butchering)	Medium	1,592	-4%	$151.4M	+26%	$32.0K	52%
Business email compromise & false billing	Low	445	-29%	$31.5M	+13%	$38.0K	4%
Romance scam	Medium	368	-14%	$26.0M	+26%	$30.0K	48%
Job scams & money-mule recruitment	High	759	-22%	$15.8M	-2%	$14.2K	11%
Recovery pitch (re-victimization)	Medium	486	+50%	$15.6M	+336%	$17.6K	55%
Bank investigator / impersonation	High	899	-37%	$11.5M	+4%	$10.0K	37%
Advance fee (prize, loan, grant, inheritance)	Medium	430	-25%	$7.9M	+26%	$2.4K	36%
Extortion (CRA, sextortion, threats)	Medium	833	-37%	$7.1M	-3%	$6.0K	13%
Service & tech-support scams	Medium	1,307	-41%	$6.5M	-27%	$1.5K	31%
Marketplace / merchandise (non-delivery)	High	936	-37%	$3.4M	-19%	$0.3K	15%
Seller-side / overpayment & fake payment notice	High	180	-43%	$1.7M	+40%*	$1.4K	54%
Emergency / grandparent scam	Medium	219	-54%	$1.0M	-25%	$3.0K	59%
Charity, psychic & other	Low	27	-50%	$0.3M	-26%	$2.0K	40%
Identity fraud (new accounts / loans in victim's name)	Medium	3,975	-16%	$0.0M	n/a	n/a	n/a
Phishing → account takeover	High	2,517	-8%	$0.0M	n/a	n/a	n/a

Highlighted rows: loss growth of 20%+ that still holds after removing each period's 3 largest reports. * = growth driven by a few very large reports; treat with caution. Report counts are falling across almost all categories as overall CAFC volumes decline, so median loss and mix are the better signals.

Monthly reported losses, largest High-exposure typologies



How scammers make contact	Share now	vs year ago
Direct call	34%	-1.0 pts
Internet-social network	20%	+0.9 pts
Email	15%	-0.5 pts
Internet	14%	-1.6 pts
Text message	12%	+2.2 pts
Door to door/in person	3%	-0.6 pts

Watch list (from bulletins)

• Deepfakes and AI voice cloning appeared in 6 recent bulletins and could amplify bank investigator impersonation and emergency scams by defeating voice-based authentication and family recognition.

• One-time passcode theft tactics (4 bulletins) directly threaten phishing-to-account-takeover scenarios and any control relying on SMS or email verification.

• Fake payment notifications via email or text (1 bulletin) enable seller-side overpayment scams and could undermine trust in legitimate Interac e-Transfer alerts.

The Payment Scam Kill Chain: where each scam can be broken

Contact → **Pretext** → **Payment request** → **Fund movement** → **Cash-out**. Each scam passes through these stages; a control at any stage breaks the chain. Controls nearer the payment stage are where a payments network has the most direct leverage.

Typology	Contact	Pretext	Payment request	Fund movement	Cash-out
Investment / crypto scam (incl. pig butchering)	• Takedown pipeline for deepfake investment ads with platforms		• Risk flag on repeated escalating transfers to crypto on-ramps		• Faster freeze/recall coordination with Canadian crypto exchanges
Business email compromise & false billing			• Payee-name check when supplier banking details change		
Romance scam		• Dating-platform warnings when users move conversation off-platform	• Pattern flag: repeated sends to one new payee with escalating amounts		
Job scams & money-mule recruitment	• Campus / youth awareness: 'if a job pays you to move money, you are the mule'			• Mule-behaviour detection: new accounts that receive and immediately forward funds	
Recovery pitch (re-victimization)	• Proactive outreach to known victims warning about recovery scams				
Bank investigator / impersonation	• Telco caller-ID authentication + bank number spoof blocking		• Scam-specific in-flow warning when a first-time payee is added shortly after an inbound call ('Your bank will never ask you to move money')	• Shared mule-account signals across institutions on the receiving side	
Advance fee (prize, loan, grant, inheritance)		• Awareness: legitimate lenders and prizes never require an up-front fee			
Extortion (CRA, sextortion, threats)		• Targeted awareness for newcomers and teens ('CRA never demands payment by e-Transfer, gift card or bitcoin')	• Retailer gift-card purchase limits and point-of-sale warnings		
Service & tech-support scams			• Detect remote-access software active during a banking session		

Typology	Contact	Pretext	Payment request	Fund movement	Cash-out
Marketplace / merchandise (non-delivery)			• Recipient-name display / confirmation before sending to a new payee	• Velocity signals on recipient accounts receiving many first-time payments	
Seller-side / overpayment & fake payment notice	• Brand-impersonation email/domain takedowns for fake payment notices	• Consumer education: real e-Transfers are deposited through your own bank app, never via an emailed link			
Emergency / grandparent scam		• Family 'safe word' public awareness campaigns aimed at seniors	• Branch / ATM teller scripts for large unusual cash withdrawals by seniors		
Identity fraud (new accounts / loans in victim's name)				• Stronger digital identity verification at account opening to cut synthetic/mule accounts	
Phishing → account takeover	• Brand-impersonation on smishing/phishing takedown service		• Step-up authentication when a new device adds a payee and sends within minutes		

Recommendations

#	Recommendation	Stage	Effort	Cost	Impact
1	**Risk flag on repeated escalating transfers to crypto on-ramps** (Investment / crypto scam (incl. pig butchering); owner: FIs) Investment scams account for $151.4M (54% of losses) with 26% growth and medium Interac exposure; flagging repeated escalating transfers to crypto on-ramps targets the payment choke-point where victims liquidate savings before losses crystallize.	Payment request	Med	Med	High
2	**Proactive outreach to known victims warning about recovery scams** (Recovery pitch (re-victimization); owner: FIs / police) Recovery pitch losses jumped 336% to $15.6M as fraudsters circle back to a known victim pool; proactive outreach costs little and directly interrupts re-victimization before the second payment leaves the account.	Contact	Low	Low	Med
3	**Campus / youth awareness: 'if a job pays you to move money, you are the mule'** (Job scams & money-mule recruitment; owner: Network / schools) Job scams remain high Interac exposure with $15.8M in losses and a $14,200 median; youth-focused awareness addresses the recruitment funnel before individuals become money mules, reducing downstream transaction risk across all typologies.	Contact	Low	Low	Med

Method and caveats. Trends use the CAFC Fraud Reporting System open dataset (Canada only); the CAFC estimates only a small fraction of fraud is reported, so figures show direction and mix, not totals. Recent months may rise as late reports arrive. Typology mapping, Interac exposure and effort/cost/impact scores are analyst judgements, documented in the project's taxonomy file. Recommendations are ranked by (impact ÷ effort+cost) × exposure × √loss share × growth. Bulletin facts were extracted with Claude and link back to source pages. Control ideas are candidates for discussion, not claims about current practice.